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Healthcare Innovation NEWS

Making A Case For Healthcare Innovation

Tufts Medical Center Streamlines Payments for Clinical Trial Participants

Program Objectives:

- Make administrative processes more efficient.
- Gain financial control and transparency.
- Support compliance and reporting needs.
- Support a better patient experience.

Program Description: Tufts Medical Center is an internationally respected, academic medical center located in the heart of Boston. Aside from providing patient care, the center conducts clinical trials and studies that make it necessary for site coordinators to assume administrative duties, such as scheduling visits, compiling data and handling patient reimbursements.

While these responsibilities could be expected at any site, the coordinators realized that there were areas where technology—specifically payment software—could improve operational efficiencies and even improve patient experience.

Efficient patient reimbursement is vital to clinical trials to eliminate any barriers to engagement and participation. Delays in payments can impact a patient's interest in returning. Tufts realized that manually processing payments and reimbursements with cash or check was wasting time and resources and was not ideal for trial participants.

For every patient visit, which could be as many as 25 each day, coordinators would have to walk 10 to 15 minutes to the petty cash office and provide documentation indicating the reason for a patient visit and why cash was needed. This process required the team to take additional steps in preparing for each patient visit.

When a patient was being reimbursed via a check, anything more than $100 required coordinators to submit a request, triggering a host of additional administrative processes through the finance department and causing a major delay in patient payment.

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Tufts found itself with a host of growing administrative processes to support patient reimbursements that were distracting from research, patient care and the ability to simply do its job. These manual processes also did not support the ability to track, monitor and audit payment transactions.

Tufts sought a means to simplify and automate payment process. In 2011, the center partnered with Greenphire, whose ClinCard solution proved to be just what it needed to streamline the patient payment process and take the administrative burden off staff.

ClinCard is the only patented payment technology designed to simplify clinical trial reimbursement and provide a patient-centric experience. The reloadable debit card reminds participants of upcoming appointments related to a trial and provides research sites a complete audit trail of all global payments, while maintaining blinded patient identities.

In addition, through the ClinCard Travel Module, trial participants could travel for a study without incurring out-of-pocket costs, further eliminating any hurdles that might prevent participation.

The ClinCard solution has enabled the research administration department at Tufts Medical Center to take a centralized view into all payments and transactions. "The research administrators that serve as approvers love the ability to run reports and simply export them to Excel. They can reconcile study budgets, see if all patients have been paid and if we're getting payments from sponsors. All of the information is in one place, a luxury we would not have without the ClinCard," says Emily Cameron, research administrator at Tufts Medical Center.

The IRS requires that 1099s be generated when patients are paid more than $600 over the course of a year. The ClinCard solution provides Tufts with an easy way to run a report indicating which of its patients require a 1099 form. Previously, this manual process would take up a significant amount of an administrator's time.

Evaluation Process: Tufts proved to be an ideal hospital for an automated, patient reimbursement solution designed for clinical research and eliminating the administrative burdens of manually executing patient reimbursements. Within three years of implementing the ClinCard solution, 100% of Tufts' studies were using the ClinCard solution and had moved away from petty cash and checks as means of reimbursement.

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Tufts Streamlines Clinical Trial Payments *(continued from page 1)*

"The solution is very easy to navigate—especially with many users—and user-friendly enabling anyone to jump right in," Cameron says.

Greenphire provides more than just a technology, striving to ensure all clients' needs are met. As an institution with many users and research studies occurring simultaneously, Tufts wanted assurance that if any support issues arose, Greenphire would address and resolve them quickly. "Regardless of the issue or who is calling, patients with questions about their ClinCards or a coordinator asking about the financial trail of a payment, Greenphire is prompt to respond and get the issue resolved," Cameron says.

Results: Since implementing ClinCard, Tufts has shifted from paper trail to electronic tracking and is now able to pay patients immediately via the reloadable debit card, resulting in a measurable increase in productivity and patient satisfaction. Ultimately, the ability to provide real-time, patient reimbursement enables Tufts' staff to further support a better clinical trial experience with the compassion and care it is committed to providing.

In addition, if Tufts Medical Center were to see 25 subjects a day, and each coordinator spent 10 to 15 minutes walking to the petty case office per visit, the implementation of ClinCard could result in a total time savings of at least four hours per day.

A pharmaceutical company implemented a pilot of the ClinCard solution, using the automated patient messaging feature, to gauge the impact that automated reimbursement could have on patient retention.[1] In the four studies completed by the sponsor, which included three adult and one pediatric trial, there was a patient retention increase of nearly 10%.

Lessons Learned:

- Implementing ClinCard has significantly reduced the manual administrative work required of Tufts' staff, giving back valuable time to spend with patients.
- ClinCard's centralized portal creates a simplified workflow with a view into transactional history, improving financial transparency for sites and sponsors.
- The automated payment process has made life easier for staff while increasing patient satisfaction, resulting in more successful trials.

[1] "Top Five Pharmaceutical Company Sees increase in Patient Retention With ClinCard." Greenphire. Accessed May 15, 2017.

Industry News

New AASM SleepTM Select Video Platform Accelerates Telemedicine Integration

DARIEN, Ill.—The American Academy of Sleep Medicine has introduced AASM Sleep™ Select, a streamlined telemedicine system that enables sleep medicine professionals, accredited sleep centers and durable medical equipment (DME) providers to rapidly improve patient access to care by integrating secure video visits.

AASM Sleep Select is a sleek, state-of the-art system comprising two elements that are essential for a quick entry into telemedicine: a HIPAA-complaint, web-based video platform and a patient self-pay feature that facilitates convenient, secure payments. Its ease of use makes the system the perfect selection for sleep specialists and DME providers who want to conduct their first video consultations and follow-up visits. To expedite the widespread adoption of telemedicine in the field of sleep medicine, the AASM is making AASM Sleep Select available for free to all of its 2,500 accredited sleep centers.

AASM SleepTM Select is available now with no set-up fee nor annual fee, plus unlimited minutes for the first 30 days, for all AASM-accredited member sleep centers. The same offer is available for AASM-accredited, non-member sleep centers that register by July 31, 2017. The simplified online registration process now allows for immediate implementation of video encounter scheduling.

Industry News

PARTNERS HEALTHCARE | CENTER FOR CONNECTED HEALTH

Partners Connected Health Launches 2017 Connected Health Innovation Challenge

BOSTON—Partners Connected Health has launched the 2017 Partners Connected Health Innovation Challenge (CHIC) following a successful pilot last year. The challenge was created to accelerate the development of disruptive, patient-centric and connected health solutions from Partners' employees and clinical faculty to radically improve the lives of patients.

“Advances in technology continue to disrupt the healthcare ecosystem. By supporting technology innovation, we can continue to advance care and clinical outcomes for our patients,” says Gregg Meyer, M.D., chief clinical officer, Partners HealthCare. “CHIC helps to identify the most innovative and promising ideas from within the Partners network, and provides expertise from our Connected Health Innovation team to create cutting-edge solutions to address our biggest healthcare challenges."

Applications will be accepted from throughout the Partners HealthCare network, comprised of 66,000 employees and more than 10,000 clinicians. External applicants with at least one team member affiliated with Partners are welcome to apply. Challenges run in approximately four-month cycles throughout the year. Proposals are evaluated based on innovation, applicability and potential to disrupt the status quo of healthcare delivery. The review committee seeks novel ideas that may include a device, mobile-based application or other technology-enabled approach to care delivery.

Selected teams will participate in a two-day workshop with Partners Connected Health Innovation leaders and receive tools and guidance on user-centered design to help further develop their ideas. Four teams will pitch their ideas to a panel of key decision makers from the Partners system, as well as industry experts.

Thought Leaders’ Corner

Q. Are Today’s Healthcare Technologies, Such as Artificial Intelligence, 3D Printing, Innovative Medical Devices and Wearables, Worth the Money?

Technology innovations can be a valuable investment in healthcare. However, the success of a technology largely depends on striking the right balance between the needs of practicing physicians and their patients.

Making the decision on which technologies are right to spend time and resources on is something that varies from physician to physician. Each practitioner has different needs based on the size of his/her practice and available financial resources. The key is to know what innovation is right for a practice and patients it serves. In some cases, physicians spend valuable resources on technology that is too advanced for their needs. This results in wasted time and resources—neither of which improves patient care.

Before physicians implement technology, they need to have a clear idea of their goals and weigh the benefits for patients today, tomorrow and years into the future. I’ve been in healthcare for more than 40 years and when it comes to technologies worth investing in, I encourage every physician—no matter the size of a practice—to focus on precision medicine and predictive modeling.

At Heritage Medical Systems, our physician groups recognize that a patient’s health is impacted by factors beyond what a doctor might see when a patient comes in for a checkup. By using technologies, such as predictive modeling, physicians can not only treat patients more effectively when they need care, but they also can help track an entire patient population to optimize its health status before anyone needs help.

Technology advancements are all about balancing the needs of physicians and their patients. Healthcare is moving forward in part because of technology and because there are so many opportunities to innovate. Physician practices should be a part of that forward-thinking and technologically innovative future.



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Thought Leaders' Corner

Fears that mechanization and robots will end the need for a human workforce have existed since the beginning of the industrial revolution. These fears aren't unfounded; jobs defined by repetitive manual tasks have been consistently replaced by technology, which has led to workforce upheaval in the past. With advancements in automation, robotics and artificial intelligence (AI), manual, repetitive and predictable tasks are further primed to be replaced by machines—a source of considerable fear today.

Within the world of healthcare, we can imagine the use of technology to make healthcare more effective and jobs easier. The dangerous tasks of lifting patients, testing for infectious viruses and blood and even sterilization of tools and equipment are obviously things that will benefit from new technologies. We are at a stage where we have loads of data to utilize: patient medical history records, treatment and outcome data and lately, information coming from wearable health trackers and sensors. This huge amount of data can be analyzed to provide not only recommendations to patients for lifestyle changes, but also used as instructive pieces of information about how to design healthcare based on the needs and habits of patients.

It is important to remember that healthcare is about humans first and foremost. The need for relational "soft skills," such as resolving conflict and working among a corporate hierarchy, however, will most likely always require a human touch. Every challenge also presents an opportunity for growth and reinvention. As today's workers meet these challenges, it is refreshing that industry leaders are reimagining the role of education within the workplace rather than apart from it.



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Today's healthcare technologies are worth the money invested as they represent innovative progress on several fronts. Whether we're talking about AI, 3D printing, medical devices and wearables, they're examples of an investment in the future application of both medicine and health.

There are multiple ways in which healthcare technologies will benefit both patients and the physicians who care for them. Take medical devices and wearables as an example. We are just starting to scratch the surface of intraoperatively, customized medical devices, but the ability to custom design and immediately print a sterile surgical implant based on a specific patients anatomy is steadily becoming a reality.

And the comprehensive information that current wearables can provide is critical. They can chart, track, accumulate data and send urgent notifications on a whole host of illnesses that already require monitoring. Improving these technologies to benefit a patient's well-being, while contributing to the efficiencies of a physician, is a win-win proposition.

Likewise, hospital systems and medical groups are seeing the benefit of upgrading their healthcare technologies and continuing to innovate. It's an extremely competitive field, and these organizations must be able to appeal to patients as the resource with the most innovative healthcare solutions available to the public. Much like those of us in the device field, hospital administrators and CTOs are actively engaged in finding technological solutions that streamline complex practice workflows.

The future of modernized healthcare is dependent on progress, and that's where we hope to continue participating.



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Mari Edlin serves as editor of *Healthcare Innovation News*. She invites you to submit bylined articles on innovations in healthcare and case studies describing forward-thinking examples. For more information, contact her at MLEdlin@comcast.net.